SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #112 · GRACE & WORKS

“The more I do for God, the more He loves me.”

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Where it often comes from

A home where affection came through achievement. Church recognition for the most active members. Perfectionism and a drive to prove yourself. Comparing your service with others. Feeling loved only when productive.

What Scripture teaches

God’s love is not a reward for what you do. Love consists in this: not that we loved God, but that He loved us and sent His Son. Christ died for us while we were still powerless and ungodly. Nothing can separate us from God’s love, and nothing you do can increase it. You can serve God with joy, but you cannot earn more of a love that is already complete.

> *“And love consists in this: not that we loved God, but that He loved us and sent His Son as the atoning sacrifice for our sins”* **(1 John 4:10)**.

Also see

> “For at just the right time, while we were still powerless, Christ died for the ungodly” **(Romans 5:6)**.

> “For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor principalities, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord” **(Romans 8:38–39)**.

> “For it is by grace you have been saved through faith, and this not from yourselves; it is the gift of God, not by works, so that no one can boast” **(Ephesians 2:8–9)**.

> “So he got up and went to his father. But while he was still in the distance, his father saw him and was filled with compassion. He ran to his son, embraced him, and kissed him” **(Luke 15:20)**.

Common self-statements

- God loves me more when I serve more.
- If I slow down, God will love me less.
- I have to keep proving my love to God.
- Busy Christians are God’s favorites.
- My worth is measured by my service.
- God’s love has to be earned.

Common logical errors

- **Conditional love:** Believing God’s love rises and falls with your performance.
- **Comparison:** Measuring God’s love for you against others’ service.
- **Projection:** Picturing God’s love like a parent who rewarded achievement.
- **Burnout thinking:** Pushing harder and harder to feel loved.

Challenging questions

- According to 1 John 4:10, who loved first?
- When did Christ die for us?
- Can anything separate me from God's love?
- Did the prodigal son earn his father's embrace?
- If I could never serve again, would God love me less?
- Am I serving to get love or because I have it?
- What would serving from security look like?

Truth summary

> God's love for me does not grow with my service. He loved me first, sent His Son for me while I was powerless, and nothing can separate me from His love. I can serve Him joyfully because I am already fully loved, not to earn more love.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Love, By God
- Grace
- Servant
- Self-Esteem, Low
- God, All Loving

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> **Overcoming Depression** · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "The more I do for God, the more He loves me"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"The more I do for God, the more He loves me." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who loved first?
- ☐ When did Christ die for us?
- ☐ Can anything separate me from God's love?
- ☐ Did the prodigal earn his father's embrace?
- ☐ Would God love me less if I couldn't serve?
- ☐ Do I serve to get love or because I have it?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God loved me first.
- ☐ God's love is not a reward for my service.
- ☐ Nothing can separate me from His love.
- ☐ I cannot earn more of a love that is complete.
- ☐ I serve because I am loved.
- ☐ Christ died for me while I was powerless.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **1 John 4:10**
  "And love consists in this: not that we loved God, but that He loved us and sent His Son as the atoning sacrifice for our sins."
- [ ] **Romans 5:6**
  "For at just the right time, while we were still powerless, Christ died for the ungodly."
- [ ] **Romans 8:38–39**
  "For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor principalities, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord."
- [ ] **Ephesians 2:8–9**
  "For it is by grace you have been saved through faith, and this not from yourselves; it is the gift of God, not by works, so that no one can boast."
- [ ] **Luke 15:20**
  "So he got up and went to his father. But while he was still in the distance, his father saw him and was filled with compassion. He ran to his son, embraced him, and kissed him."

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Loved already log:** Each day, write: "God loves me fully today," and one way I served out of joy, not pressure.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Romans 5:6 becomes: "For at just the right time, while **Sarah** was still powerless, Christ died for **her**."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Love, By God" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Take one day this week with no ministry tasks** and spend part of it simply enjoying God.
- ☐ **Read Luke 15:11–24,** and write what the father did before his son could earn anything.
- ☐ **Step back from one commitment** you took on only to feel valued.
- ☐ **Write a thank-you prayer for God's love** without listing anything you have done for Him.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "The more I do for God, the more He loves me": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One reminder that I'm loved already
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~The more I do for God, the more He loves me.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, thank You that You loved me first, before I ever did anything for You. Help me reject the lie that the more I do for You, the more You love me. Let me rest in Your complete love and serve You out of joy. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.